같은 '-요', 다른 뜻: 문장 끝 억양 듣고 읽기

Learn how the tone at the end of a sentence turns -아요/어요 into a statement, question, suggestion, or command.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

You can read a short dialogue with tone marks (↗ ↘ →) and tell each line's meaning, and choose the right tone for 네, 왜요, 그래요 and -죠.

1 ONE ENDING, MANY TONES

1. **가요.↘** (statement)
   A falling tone tells a fact.
   예: 저는 지금 은행에 가요.↘
2. **가요?↗** (question)
   A rising tone on the last syllable makes it a question.
   예: 지금 집에 가요?↗
3. **같이 가요.→** (suggestion (let's))
   A soft, level tone, often with 같이 or 우리, means "let's."
   예: 우리 같이 점심 먹어요.→
4. **빨리 가요.↘** (command (please do))
   A short, firm fall tells someone to do something.
   예: 늦었어요. 빨리 준비해요.↘
5. **-죠?↗** (checking)
   Rise when you think it's true but want to check.
   예: 내일 시험 있죠?↗
6. **-네요.↘** (noticing something new)
   End gently, without a rise, when you just noticed something.
   예: 와, 사람이 정말 많네요.↘
7. **네?↗ / 네.↘** (Pardon? / Yes.)
   Rising asks the person to repeat; falling means yes.
   예: 네?↗ 다시 한 번 말해 주세요.
8. **그래요?↗ / 그래요.↘** (Really? / OK.)
   Rising shows surprise or interest; falling accepts or agrees.
   예: A: 내일 쉬어요. B: 그래요?↗ 좋겠다!
9. **왜요?↗ / 왜요.↘** (Why? / What now?)
   A soft rise is a real question; a short flat fall can sound annoyed.
   예: A: 잠깐만요. B: 네, 왜요?↗

2 READING TIP: LISTEN TO THE LAST SYLLABLE

In English, a question usually changes the word order (You are going → Are you going?). In Korean, 가요 stays the same, and only the tone of the last syllable changes.

Feeling matters too. A very short, flat ending can sound cold, especially in 네 and 왜요.

Copyright © 2026 DURU KOREAN. All rights reserved.
For personal and educational use only. Commercial use, redistribution, or reproduction without the author's permission is prohibited.

3 READ THE DIALOGUE: FIND THE FOUR MEANINGS

수진: 민수 씨, 점심 먹었어요?↗

민수: 아직요. 지금 먹으러 가요.↘

수진: 그래요?↗ 그럼 같이 가요.→

민수: 좋아요. 근데 오늘 오후에 비 오죠?↗

수진: 네, 온대요.↘ 우산 꼭 챙겨요.↘

민수: 어, 벌써 오네요.↘

The arrows show the tone of the last syllable: ↗ rising, ↘ falling, → level and soft.

4 YOUR TURN

READ THE TONE, FIND THE MEANING

Use the tone marks ↗ (rising), ↘ (falling), and → (level, soft) to decide what each sentence means or which tone fits the situation.

1 Write ↗ or ↘ for each sentence:
①(You are asking.) 이 버스 시청에 가요?
②(You are telling.) 저는 다음 역에서 내려요.
③(You didn't hear and want the person to say it again.) 네?

2 Statement, question, suggestion, or command?
①(to a friend) 주말에 같이 영화 봐요.→
②(a teacher to students) 책 덮어요.↘
③(to a coworker) 점심 벌써 먹었어요?↗

3 Fill in the blank with -죠 and add a tone mark. You think the meeting is at three, but you are not sure, so you check with a coworker:
회의가 세 ____

4 Read and answer in English: A: 민호 씨, 내일 저녁에 시간 있어요?↗ B:
왜요.↘ (short and flat) — How might A feel? Write a friendlier reply for B in Korean.

5 True or False:
①A short, flat, falling 왜요↘ always sounds friendly.
②"밖에 눈이 오네요" usually ends with a gentle falling tone.

✓ ANSWERS

1) ① ↗ ② ↘ ③ ↗
2) ① suggestion ② command ③ question
3) 시죠?↗ (회의가 세 시죠?↗ / 세 시지요?↗)
4) A may feel that B is annoyed or doesn't want to talk. Friendlier reply: 네, 있어요. 왜요?↗ (or just 왜요?↗ with a soft rising tone)
5) ① False ② True

Copyright © 2026 DURU KOREAN. All rights reserved.
For personal and educational use only. Commercial use, redistribution, or reproduction without the author's permission is prohibited.